Wingmate
Project Proposal

Elliott Vince,
Teagan Wright
& Amanda Zhu

Problem Statement

Dating apps have become one of the primary ways people find romantic connections. While they allow people to access a wide range of potential partners easily, many users report frustration and negative experiences using the existing platforms on the market today. Through interviewing five potential users who are actively using, or have recently used, dating apps, several recurring problems emerged that highlight the flaws and gaps in the current dating app market.

From the perspective of our potential users, one of the most prominent issues is misrepresentation, or "catfishing". Dating app users frequently encounter profiles that exaggerate, mislead, or completely fake personal information. This creates a lack of trust and makes users feel much more skeptical and reluctant to interact with people on these apps.

Another big problem identified through our interviews is the overpresence of low-quality and effort put into profiles. Many felt like the majority of the profiles they were seeing contained poor photos, very sparse or empty bios, and information that raised immediate "red flags". This has led to feelings of frustration and discouragement from the endless scroll through profiles that don't align with their interest, values, or expectations. It can feel very time-consuming and pointless, especially if the user is looking to find a genuine and meaningful connection.

Finally, users reported finding it difficult to find people who had similar relationship goals. A common concern expressed by our potential users was that many people using existing dating apps are primarily looking for something casual or hookups. Users looking for something long-term or serious struggle to find matches with the same goals.

These problems all contribute to dating app experiences that feel frustrating, inefficient, and emotionally draining for users. The lack of trust caused by misrepresentation, in addition to low-effort profiles and misaligned intentions, makes it difficult for users to feel comfortable, confident, and motivated while using existing platforms. Users are underserved by the current dating apps available. The need for honesty, effort, and alignment in relationship goals is not being met.

User Research

Our Interviews

We conducted structured interviews with five participants. The interviews focused on participants' experiences with modern dating apps, including both positive and negative experiences, as well as their relationship goals and expectations for dating apps. Our participants were between 21 to 27 years old; there were three females and two males. Each participant had medium-high to high tech literacy and had prior experience using dating apps. Some participants were single, others were in relationships. We learned about their experiences finding new relationships, and the experience of setting their friends up on dates.

Our Target User Groups

We consolidated our observations and insights into three target user groups. First, we have young singles (21 - 32 years old) who are specifically looking to enter a committed relationship. This group encompasses all genders and sexualities. The people in this group are transitioning out of school and into their professional lives, and they have medium to high tech literacy. They value authenticity and genuine connections. Our next group represents people who are in a relationship and are willing to help their friends find a relationship. Members of this group are not looking for a relationship for themselves, since they already have one. They come from all genders and sexualities, and encompass all professional backgrounds. Like the first user group, this group starts at age 21, but does not have an upper age limit. Regardless of their age, members of this user group have medium to high tech literacy. Most importantly, they genuinely care for their friends and want to help them find a healthy, committed relationship. Our final user group comprises young singles belonging to the first user group who are also willing to help their friends find relationships. Like the first group, they value authenticity and genuine connections, and are seeking a committed relationship. Similar to the second group, these users are also willing to help their friends find meaningful relationships.

Planning our Interactive Prototype Study

In this project, potential users will test our design prototypes. To find people in our target user groups, we will employ several methods. We will visit coffee shops and libraries and ask patrons if they would like to participate in our study. We will randomly select who we ask so we can encourage authentic, unbiased responses. In addition, we will recruit prospective users within our target groups by posting to online resources like the Queen's University subreddit. Then, if we still need more people, we will ask friends and people in our networks to participate in our study. Our goal is to select a diverse test group so we can learn from their unique experiences and use those insights to shape our final prototype. To ensure a consistent experience for our participants, we will conduct our study in an open, neutral environment like a library or café.

User Research

User Personas

We have created three personas representing our target user groups. Each persona captures the key baseline traits, behaviours, wants and pain points of a distinct audience group. These personas, put together, reflect the diversity of our target users, while highlight how they would interact with our product.

Sophie Anderson

Age	21
Gender	Female
Occupation	4th Year University
Orientation	Straight
Tech Literacy	High

Biography

Sophie lives in London, Ontario and is in her final year of university at Western. As she prepares to graduate, she is applying for full-time jobs in Toronto and is excited to begin her life in "the real world". As she transitions into her professional life, she hopes to expand her social circle beyond university and is looking to build a meaningful, long-term romantic relationship. In her free time, she likes to try new coffee shops and local restaurants.

Core Needs

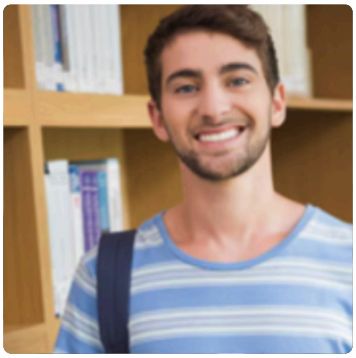
- Identifies as straight and is seeking a male partner
- Wants a serious, long-term relationship
- Wants a partner that she can meet new people/form a strong friend group with in this new city

Frustrations

- She is frustrated with university and dating app hookup culture, which makes it difficult to find people interested in serious, long-term relationships
- She finds it challenging to form meaningful connections in a new city where she has no existing social network
- She is worried that moving to a new city will make it harder to organically meet both friends and romantic partners

User Research

Mark Williams



Age	23
Gender	Male
Occupation	Electrician
Orientation	Straight
Tech Literacy	Medium-High

Biography

Mark lives in Toronto and works as a journeyman for a local construction firm. He loves his two dogs, his family, and loves meeting new people. Having recently moved to the city from Minnesota, he is looking to start dating and finding love.

Core Needs

- Wants to find his life-long romantic partner
- Wants to be assured that potential partners are also looking for long-term relationships
- Wants a partner who enjoys a similarly active lifestyle

Frustrations

- Since he has been single for over seven years, Mark fears the general unknown of dating and is unsure how it works with dating apps
- It is hard to find potential partners in his field of work (since it's very male-dominated)
- He has limited time for scrolling/finding dates due to his busy work schedule

Kathy Xu

Age	28
Gender	Female
Occupation	Molecular Biologist
Orientation	Bisexual
Tech Literacy	High

Biography

Kathy lives in Halifax and works as a molecular biologist for the Nova Scotia government. She cares deeply about the environment and is very introverted. In her time off, she loves to surf, cook, and read. She is the only person within her friend group who is currently in a healthy long-term relationship.

Core Needs

- Wants her friends to find love so they can build lifelong friendships as couples
- Wants to be able to support her friends by helping them find good partners

Frustrations

- She is frustrated with how her friends keep wasting their time on dating apps and are never able to find successful connections
- Kathy wants to help her friends find relationships but does not know anyone to set them up with
- Since her friends have been ghosted on dating apps and are hesitant to try them again, she wants to find a dating app with less short-term culture

Figures & Illustrations

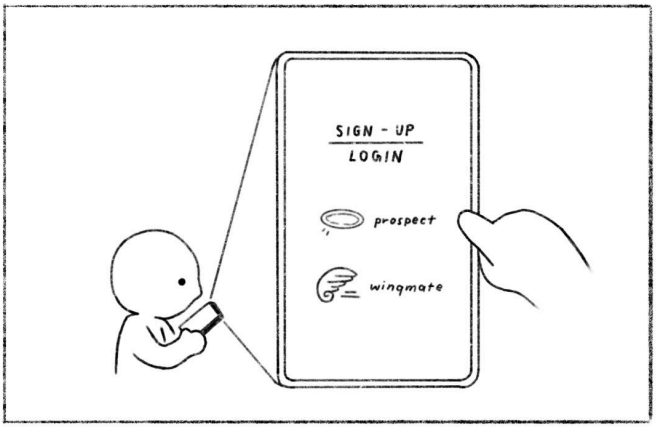


Figure 1: after downloading and opening the app, the user signs up, choosing either the "wingmate" or "prospect" route (this illustration will demonstrate the prospect route).

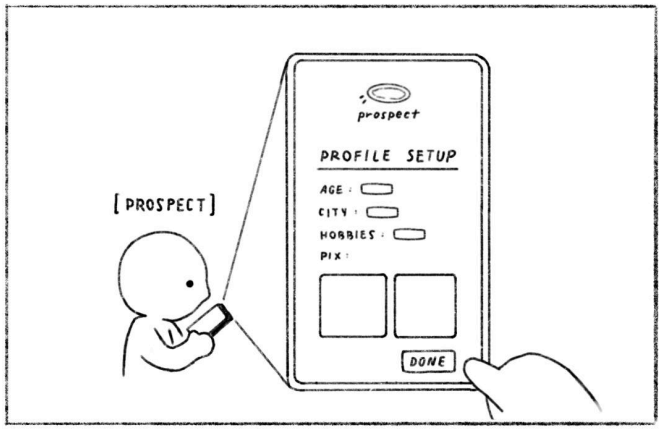


Figure 2: the user has chosen the "prospect" route. The user proceeds by setting up their profile, answering baseline questions, pictures, etc.

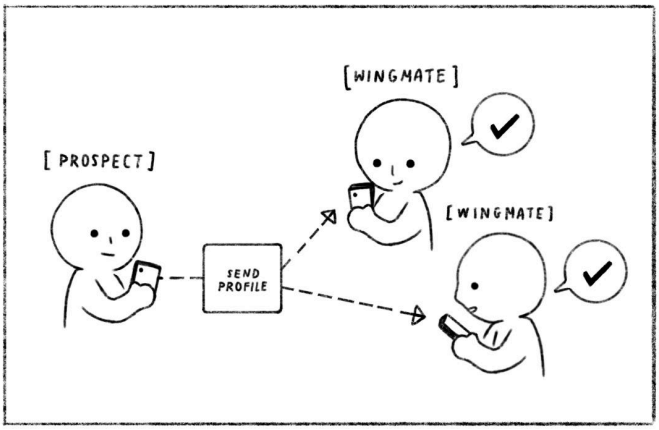


Figure 3. The prospect sends their profile to wingmate(s) for profile completion, which includes answering prompts about the prospect and giving a "stamp of approval" (indicating authenticity of their profile).

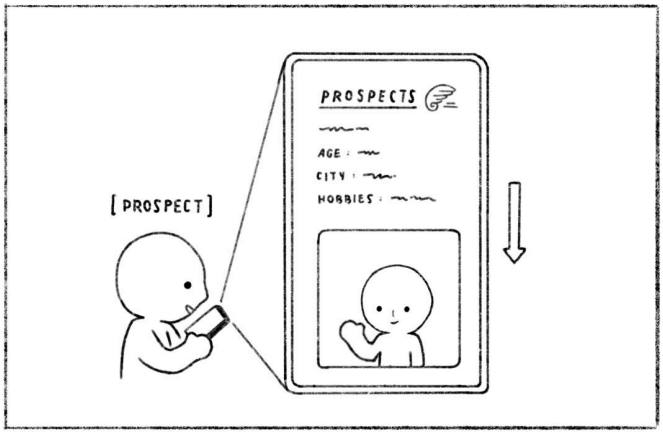
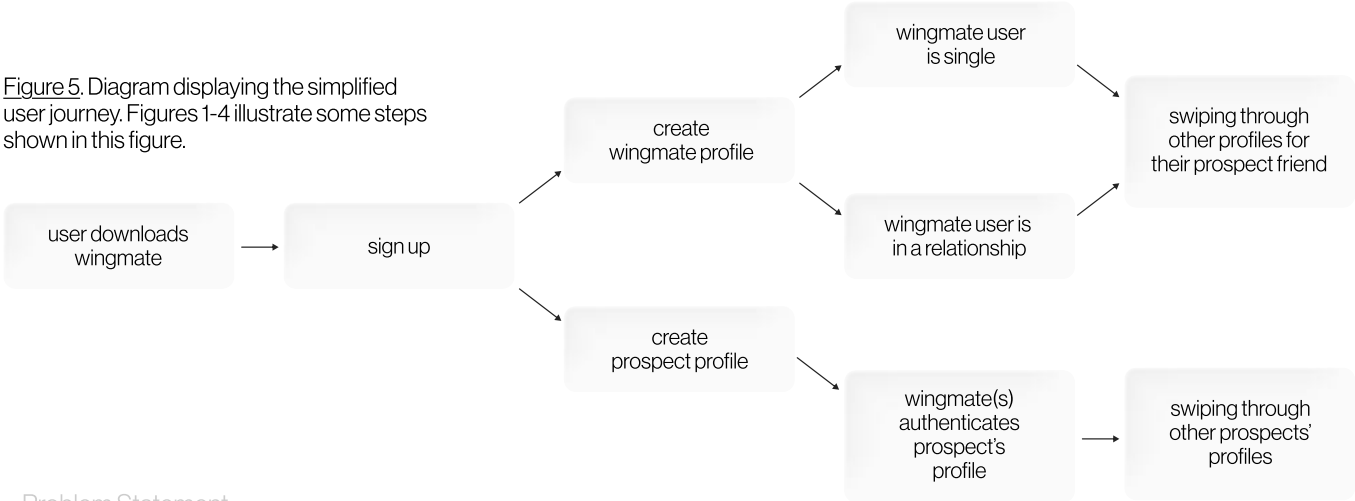


Figure 4. After the prospect's profile has been validated by wingmates, the prospect may begin scrolling through other prospects' profiles, to look for their potential partner.

Figure 5. Diagram displaying the simplified user journey. Figures 1-4 illustrate some steps shown in this figure.



Group Coordination Plan

Our group plans to meet every Thursday at 2:30 pm in the CasLab. Based on everyone's schedules, if this meeting needs to be moved, we will agree on a new time, but we have committed to meeting together at a minimum once a week. We will meet with our TA during active learning session weeks and will check in with her during our weekly meetings on weeks we do not see her in class. At our weekly check-ins, we will discuss the work we have completed and will go over next steps and who will complete what tasks. We maintain regular communication through our Discord group chat and have committed to responding to messages within at least 24 hours. We will upload all shared files to our shared Google Drive.

Week	Date	Tasks
2	Jan 14th (4:30 - 5:30 pm)	Completed group agreement (due Jan 21st) Brainstormed Project Proposal
2	**Jan 21st**	**Group Agreement due**
3	Jan 23rd (1:00 - 3:00 pm)	Continued project proposal (user research: listed out questions and potential interviewees, assigned tasks before next meeting, communicated with our TA on project questions)
4	Tues Jan 27th (11:00 am - 1:30 pm)	Meeting with TA (Beth) for assignment (project proposal) questions, Continue project proposal work. Split up the final tasks to finalize the A1 submission.
4	**Jan 29th**	**Project Proposal Due**
5	Tentative- Feb 5th	Meet to go over A2 requirements. Begin work and split up tasks.
6	Tentative- Feb 12th	Meet to check in on progress and assign tasks for reading week.
Reading Week	Possible virtual meeting if needed- Feb 19th	Meet virtually if needed. Finish tasks and finalize A2 submission.
7	Tentative- Feb 26th	Finish tasks and finalize A2 submission.
7	**Feb 26th**	**Low-Fi Prototype Due**
8	Tentative- Mar 5th	Meet to go over A3 requirements. Begin work and split up tasks.
9	Tentative- Mar 12th	Meet to check in on progress and assign remaining tasks.
10	Tentative- Mar 19th	Meet to finalize any last tasks and prepare the final submission.
11		**Mar 26- Final Paper & Video Due**